

# Sticky Toffee Pudding

Dates bloomed with soda for a silky crumb. Dark muscovado + treacle for caramel that's deep, not flat. A two-stage sauce finished off-heat with whisky, poured hot so the sponge drinks it dark.

Yield: **10–12** (20×20 cm)    Active: **15 min**    Total: **1 hr 15**    Oven: **170°C** (340°F)    Done: **94°C** internal

|                                                                                                                                                                                                             |                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                                                                                                                                                                                     |
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| <b>WHERE IT WAS BORN</b><br>England by name, contested by fact — oldest claim the <i>Gait Inn</i> , Millington, Yorkshire (1907); the famous line runs through Lancashire from two Canadian wartime airmen. | <b>EATEN, AUTHENTICALLY</b><br>Hot, the sponge skewered and drowned in toffee sauce, with cold <i>clotted cream</i> — a country-house dining-room pudding made famous at Sharrow Bay in the 1970s. | <b>HOW IT'S USED NOW</b><br>A pub and restaurant fixture worldwide; the same date batter becomes sticky ginger & walnut pudding (below), and the sauce stands alone over ice cream. |
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## INGREDIENTS

WEIGHT ONLY · VOLUME / NOTE IN RIGHT COLUMN

### DATE BASE

|                                               |      |          |
|-----------------------------------------------|------|----------|
| Medjool dates, pitted ( <i>deglet works</i> ) | 220g | ~1¼ cups |
| Boiling water                                 | 280g | 1¼ cups  |
| Baking soda ( <i>it foams</i> )               | 6g   | 1 tsp    |

### CAKE

|                                      |      |             |
|--------------------------------------|------|-------------|
| Unsalted butter, soft                | 100g | 7 tbsp      |
| Dark muscovado sugar                 | 175g | scant 1 cup |
| Black treacle ( <i>or molasses</i> ) | 25g  | 1 tbsp      |
| Egg, whole ( <i>RT</i> )             | 100g | 2 large     |
| Vanilla extract                      | 5g   | 1 tsp       |
| Plain flour                          | 175g | 1½ cups     |
| Baking powder                        | 4g   | 1 tsp       |
| Fine sea salt                        | 3g   | ½ tsp       |

### WHISKY CARAMEL SAUCE

|                                       |      |             |
|---------------------------------------|------|-------------|
| Dark muscovado sugar                  | 150g | ¾ cup       |
| Unsalted butter ( <i>cubed</i> )      | 100g | 7 tbsp      |
| Double cream ( <i>35%+</i> )          | 200g | scant 1 cup |
| Vanilla extract                       | 5g   | 1 tsp       |
| Dark whisky / rum ( <i>off-heat</i> ) | 30g  | 2 tbsp      |
| Flaky sea salt                        | 3g   | ½ tsp       |

**THE RATIO — FLOUR = 100%**  
**Flour 100 · Sugar 100 · Butter 57 · Egg 57 · Dates 125.** A near 1:1:1 pound-cake frame carried by its own weight again in soft date — that date load holds the sauce.

Kit: 20×20 cm (8") square pan or 8 ramekins · heavy small saucepan · scale · instant-read thermometer · whisk · skewer

## METHOD

- Bloom the dates.** Stir 6g soda into 280g boiling water until clear, pour over 220g pitted dates, stand **15 min**. Blend smooth; cool to **≤40°C** before the batter.

Alkaline water (pH ~8) dissolves pectin so the purée goes silky + pre-reacts the dates' acid; hot purée melts the butter emulsion. — McGee 2004
- Cream the sugars.** Oven 170°C (340°F); butter + line the pan. Cream 100g butter, 175g muscovado, 25g treacle **3–4 min** until pale. A little grain is fine.

Dark muscovado = up to ~15% molasses vs light brown's ~3.5%: deeper colour, smoke, dark fruit + moist crumb. — Parks, BraveTart 2017
- Eggs, then flour + dates.** Beat in 100g egg one at a time with vanilla. Whisk flour, baking powder, salt; fold in half → all dates → rest. **Stop at 80%** — streaks fine.

Over-mixing builds gluten + air → a tall springy cake that sheds sauce. — Beranbaum, Cake Bible
- Bake + rest. 30–35 min to 94°C (200°F)** centre — matte, cracked edges, skewer tacky not wet. Rest 10 min in the pan; do not unmould.

At 94°C the starch is set but porous and warm — the state that drinks hot sauce. — McGee 2004

### Whisky Caramel — two stages, off-heat finish

- Melt 100g butter + 150g muscovado low until glossy, **3–4 min**. No graininess.
- Off heat:** whisk in 200g cream + vanilla. Back on low, **simmer 90 sec** to coat a spoon — never a hard boil, which splits it.
- Off heat:** whisk in 30g whisky + 3g flaky salt. Whisky's esters boil off above 78°C — add late, hold 70–80°C. — *Modernist Cuisine* 2011
- Skewer + drown:** 30+ holes in the warm sponge, pour ⅓, let it vanish 60 sec, then plate + drench ~40g a portion. Reserve the rest for the table.

**Done:** Sponge 94°C (200°F) internal, matte + cracked, skewer tacky. Sauce coats a spoon, glossy, unbroken.  
**Serve:** hot, soaked dark, with cold clotted cream / crème fraîche / ice cream. Pour the sauce at 70–80°C — never cold, it gels on top.

### ONE BATTER, TWO PUDDINGS — STICKY GINGER & WALNUT

The same date sponge, the Lancashire variation: add **4g ground ginger** to the dry mix, **30–40g chopped stem ginger** + **60g toasted walnuts** to the batter. Same pan, same 94°C, same whisky caramel (or a maple butterscotch). *The sauce also stands alone — 5 days fridge, gentle reheat over ice cream.*

| ELEVATION                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
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| <b>TIER 1 — NO EXTRA TIME</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                    | <b>TIER 2 — WORTH IT (+10 MIN)</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>TIER 3 — RESTAURANT</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li><b>Silan glaze</b> — swap treacle for 25g date molasses</li><li><b>Pedro Ximénez</b> — 40g PX for the whisky; fig + raisin</li><li><b>Espresso</b> — 1g instant into the sauce if skipping booze</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li><b>Brown-butter sponge</b> — brown 130g, weigh 100g</li><li><b>Burnt-honey brake</b> — 30g honey to mahogany into the sauce</li><li><b>Miso caramel</b> — 15g white miso whisked in; deeper caramel</li></ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li><b>Smoked dates</b> — cold-smoke 20 min over oak before soaking</li><li><b>Smoked clotted cream</b> — 15 min hay/applewood, covered</li><li><b>Bone-marrow crust</b> — 20g rendered marrow + salt on the warm top</li></ul> |

## TROUBLESHOOT

|                          |                                                              |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Metallic taste</b>    | Soda not dissolved. Stir into water until clear first.       |
| <b>Dense, gummy</b>      | Date purée too hot. Cool to ≤40°C — it melts the butter.     |
| <b>Sunk middle</b>       | Underbaked. Bake to a true 94°C, not on colour.              |
| <b>Sauce split</b>       | Boiled too hard. Off heat, splash cold cream, whisk hard.    |
| <b>Sauce sits on top</b> | Poured cold / crumb cold. Pour at 70–80°C on warm sponge.    |
| <b>Tastes flat</b>       | Light brown, not muscovado. Use muscovado, or +25g molasses. |

## CHARTER PREP & STORAGE

|                      |                                                                                |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>The rule</b>      | Store pudding + sauce <b>APART</b> , always. Together = split fat, mushy cake. |
| <b>Baked pudding</b> | 2 mo frozen. Reheat 120°C / 12 min, lightly pre-soaked.                        |
| <b>Toffee sauce</b>  | 2 wk fridge / 3 mo freezer. Skim fat, whisk back in 30-sec bursts.             |
| <b>Date base</b>     | 5 d fridge in a jar. Double the soak for next week.                            |
| <b>Raw ramekins</b>  | 1 mo frozen. Bake from frozen +10 min @ 165°C.                                 |
| <b>Never</b>         | Store the two together, or pour the sauce cold.                                |